



Original Research

Religious Trauma: A Phenomenological Inquiry into Impacts on Millennials

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Abstract: A paucity of research exists on the impacts of growing up religious and the possible trauma that can result from exposure to religious tenets. Through phenomenological inquiry into millennial experiences growing up in the evangelical church, the phenomenon of religious trauma is examined through the lens of participant experiences. Stories of trauma resulting from religious upbringing have been prolific in mainstream literature and social media, yet little attention has been garnered by the topic within the empirical research community. A further purpose of this study is to generate and operationalize variables for future research and create groundwork for quantitative analysis. Coded qualitative data gathered in eight interviews from participants in a sample from around the US demonstrate strong themes independent of demographics or geographic area. International participant acts as a control and further strengthens analysis of coded qualitative data. Understanding of the phenomenon benefits individuals, clergy, and religious institutions who may desire knowledge of poor outcomes. This national qualitative study was completed to understand participant experiences in an effort to better understand the phenomenon of religious trauma.

Keywords: *Religious Trauma, Religiosity, Trauma, Spirituality, Phenomenological, Qualitative, Health Outcomes*

Introduction

Religious trauma and the resulting impacts have become recent trends on social media. However, the relative silence on the topic of religious trauma within current empirical literature rests in stark contrast. The topic has become increasingly popular in mainstream culture, but the dearth of research belies the magnitude of possible negative impacts that lie along the micro-to-macro continuum. Religion is remarkably widespread in the US, with 90 percent of adults of the early 1990s stating they were Christian. While the definitions of religious trauma vary, the sheer number of individuals who claimed to be religious is notable. These numbers have been in decline since that time (Pew Research Center 2022), yet many millennials grew up in religious homes and the US maintains a highly religious populace. If even a small percentage of the individuals growing up religious maintained lasting impacts, it would be markedly problematic.

The phenomenon of religious trauma is not well operationalized or understood in empirical literature. Because this trauma is often sheltered within the very cultures in which